

Cosmic Shore

Invite-Only Playtest

Remaining scope, owners, and effort to an invite-gated release. All features and engineering are complete. The six-week milestone is now a Deadlock-style invite program, not a paid launch; paid Early Access follows as a metrics-gated beat.

Prepared	Company	Milestone type	Platform	Team
31 July 2026	Froglet Inc.	Invite-only Steam Playtest, free	Windows x64 via SteamPipe	8 contributors

102.5 PERSON-DAYS LEFT Across six workstreams and eight named owners. Net +2.0 versus the 28 July plan.	6 weeks CALENDAR PATH Unchanged. Review bounce buffer moves from week six to weeks three and four.	9/10 PUNCH-LIST PROJECTS SHIPPED The tenth, monetisation, remains deliberately cut and now waits behind the paid-EA gate.	0 FEATURES LEFT TO BUILD Still true. The invite system is Steamworks Playtest configuration, not client code.
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Where the project stands

The 28 July checkpoint pointed the six-week path at a **paid Early Access launch** modelled on Path of Exile's transition into a free live-service. That destination is unchanged — but it is no longer the next milestone. A paid EA launch opens the Steam review score on day one, while the game is at its roughest. We are instead preceding it with the model Valve used for Deadlock: an **invite-only early development release** where access spreads through friend invites, and the review surface stays closed.

The mechanism is **Steam Playtest**, which supports this natively: a free child app attached to our store page, a Request Access queue granted in throttled waves, and per-tester **friend invites** (one to three each, compounding) — the Deadlock loop, available to third parties as configuration. Critically, **playtest participants cannot post Steam reviews**, and playtest metrics never touch the base app, so the review score does not exist until we choose to open it.

What changed since 28 July

Week six now ends at the Deadlock milestone, not the Path of Exile one. Pricing, the launch discount, and the EA questionnaire (2.0 person-days) leave the window; Playtest setup and wave operations (4.0 person-days) enter it. Net change is +2.0 person-days, zero calendar change. Every quality gate and the content scope carry forward unchanged — the invite cohort gets the same build the paid launch would have gotten.

Decisions this plan locks

DECISION	POSITION
Milestone type	Invite-only early development release via Steam Playtest. Honest framing as a party game growing new vessels and episodes, now labelled an early development build. Paid Early Access is the next milestone, gated on metrics rather than a date.
Review exposure	Zero by design. Playtest participants cannot review the game; the base app remains unreleased, so no review score exists. Reviews open only at the paid-EA conversion, on a build that has already survived the invite cohort.
Access model	Request Access signup visible on the Coming Soon page, granted in throttled weekly waves, plus friend invites at one to three per tester. Grants and invites can be paused per wave from Steamworks.
Monetisation	Unchanged: none. Price, launch discount, and the EA questionnaire move behind the paid-EA gate. The entitlement-verification gap remains the blocker on any money movement.
Engineering positions	All unchanged. Netcode: UGS Relay plus Netcode for GameObjects, shipped and locked. Steam SDK: none at launch — friend invites are Playtest configuration on Valve's side, not client integration. Crash reporting: Unity Cloud Diagnostics behind the shipped consent toggle. Hardware floor: GTX 1060-class, 8 GB RAM, Windows 10 64-bit, confirmed in week three, then locked.

Already shipped

No further investment required

Unchanged from the 28 July checkpoint and restated so the remaining 102.5 person-days reads in proportion. Everything below is complete, in the repository, and playable.

PROJECT	STATUS	WHAT SHIPPED
Minigame trio	SHIPPED	Hex Race, Crystal Capture, and Joust across four intensities and one to four players, with domain-aggregated scoring and AI backfill to twelve players. Four bonus modes beyond the original slice.
Tournament mode	SHIPPED	Live as "Maelstrom". Chains Hex Race into Joust into Crystal Capture, with race-to-six placement scoring, standings, and crystal-wallet credit.
Freestyle hub and Painting Mode	SHIPPED	Full toy system: vessel changer, domain changer, sixteen-painting gallery with WebGL share export, and the Wanderway conveyor. All vessels flyable.
Netcode and sessions	SHIPPED	UGS Relay with eager per-user sessions, presence lobby, party invites, friends, kick, and disconnect handling. Works on Steam with no Steam transport required.
Time-to-Tournament	BY DESIGN	Tournament always unlocked and reachable from first boot. The quest chain is the guided progression. One validation pass remains in Workstream C.
Vessel progression economy	SHIPPED	Hangar grid plus unlock system. Vessels unlock by spending earned crystals. One tuning pass remains in Workstream C.
Telemetry	SHIPPED	PostHog sink, locked event schema, match envelope, onboarding and game funnels, consent-gated throughout. Wave cohorting lands in Workstream C.
Settings system	COMPLETE	Four-tab PC settings panel: display, resolution, v-sync, frame cap, quality, colourblind mode, subtitles, consent, invert axes, audio. Verified complete and live in the main menu and pause panel.
Performance program	ONGOING	Burst spatial index, instanced prisms, adaptive animation, diagnostics overlay, benchmark tool with sweep. Remaining work locks the floor and gates it, in Workstream D.
Legal groundwork	DRAFTED	Privacy policy template and consent setup written. Hosting and store-page linkage remain in Workstream F.

Cut from this window, retained on the roadmap

Each item was scoped, assessed, and deliberately deferred. Anything on this list appearing in a milestone conversation is scope creep. Items marked EA GATE execute in the paid-EA conversion sprint once the gate metrics hold.

CUT	WHY IT IS SAFE TO DEFER
All IAP and web checkout EA GATE	Nothing is sold in this window at all. The checkout flow retains its unresolved entitlement-verification gap and must not take money until a backend verifies orders.
Pricing, launch discount, EA questionnaire EA GATE	Newly deferred out of this window. All three are inputs to a purchasable release, which this milestone deliberately is not. They execute in the conversion sprint with real cohort data behind the price point.
Steamworks SDK integration	Not required to ship. Cloud Save roams progress and the Input System handles pads. Friend invites come from Playtest configuration, not the SDK. Achievements become a first-patch beat.
Full rebinding UI	Invert-Y and invert-throttle shipped. Steam Input covers controller remapping with no work from us.
Host migration and rejoin-in-progress	Disconnect handling exists. Migration was a multi-week task with an absence acceptable to an invite cohort, and to Early Access after it.
Localisation	English-only window. New strings continue to go into tables as they already do.
Open playtest and Next Fest	Sharper now than before: the invite program is deliberately not an open playtest. Next Fest stays reserved for the 1.0 beat, where the wishlist push matters most.
Missions, Arena games, mobile, cosmetics	Already out of scope in the prior plan. Restated so the fence moves with the project.

Remaining work, part one

Workstreams A and B · 15.0 person-days

A · Steam business and Playtest setup

1 calendar week, mostly waiting · Shombith leading setup, Caleb on Playtest configuration, Garrett on administration and policy

#	TASK	OWNER	DAYS	RUNNING
A1	Steamworks partner account, identity, tax and banking. Carries external processing lead time, so it starts first.	Shombith	1.0	1.0
A2	Pay Steam Direct fee and create the app record	Shombith	0.5	1.5
A3	Content survey and mature-content questionnaire	Garrett	0.5	2.0
A4	Create and configure the Playtest child app. Customer-visible name locked (it cannot change later), Request Access signup enabled, friend invites set at one to three per tester, grant cadence set to manual waves. Replaces the Early Access questionnaire in this window.	Caleb	1.0	3.0
A5	Coming Soon page live with the Playtest signup section visible. Every live week earns wishlists and grows the signup queue before a single grant is issued.	Caleb	1.0	4.0
A6	Wave policy signed: wave sizes, weekly caps, pause criteria tied to capacity and defect telemetry. Replaces price-setting in this window.	Garrett	0.5	4.5
A7	Submit store page and the Playtest build for Steam review. Both reviews now land mid-plan rather than at the end.	Shombith	1.0	5.5
Workstream A subtotal			5.5	5.5

B · Windows build and delivery pipeline

2 weeks, parallel with A · Shombith

#	TASK	OWNER	DAYS	RUNNING
B1	Windows x64 build profile authored and committed. Windows builds already run on a dedicated UGS automated build server; this is a verification pass plus committing the profile so the configuration is reproducible from source.	Shombith	1.0	6.5
B2	PC platform sanity pass: Wwise audio init, keyboard and mouse plus Xbox and PlayStation pads, alt-tab and focus handling, quit path from the menu, no mobile-only prompts or share dead-ends	Shombith	3.0	9.5
B3	Offline and service-outage behaviour: launching with no network reaches the menu with a clear message rather than hanging on authentication	Shombith	1.0	10.5
B4	SteamPipe upload script and branch convention, now targeting both appIDs: base app default for the future paid build, Playtest depot as the live invite channel , internal branch for the team	Shombith	1.5	12.0
B5	Automated depot build from a tagged commit on the existing UGS build server, with the steps documented	Shombith	1.5	13.5
B6	Enable Cloud Diagnostics crash reporting behind the existing consent toggle	Shombith	1.0	14.5
B7	Verify the Steam overlay renders over the game on a real Playtest build	Shombith	0.5	15.0
Workstream B subtotal			9.5	15.0

C · In-game finalising, quests, instrumentation and validation

3 to 4 weeks · Shombith and Ian on engineering and dashboards, Caleb and Garrett on quest dialogue, Charles on audio, Andrew on testing

Unchanged in scope and effort from the 28 July plan. The invite cohort receives the same finished, validated build the paid launch would have received — that is the point of the model. What remains is dialogue content, the progression data update, finalising, and end-to-end testing.

#	TASK	OWNER	DAYS	RUNNING
C1	Settings panel prefab wiring COMPLETE All four tabs verified wired and live in the main menu and pause panel.	Shombith	0	15.0
C2	First-session validation: fresh install, guest sign-in, menu, first Tournament. Confirm the quest chain and controls overlay carry a new player unaided. Observe three to five first-timers and fix only what actually stops them.	Andrew, Shombith	3.0	18.0
C3	Verify the funnel dashboard answers median time-to-Tournament from real sessions	Ian	2.0	20.0
C4	De-scope sweep of visible UI. Episode purchase surfaces, store screen, and locked screens receive deliberate coming-soon treatment rather than appearing broken. Doubly load-bearing now: the invite build is the first thing outsiders see.	Shombith	3.0	23.0
C5	Confirm vessel-unlock economy: crystal earn rates against vessel prices, one tuning pass in config	Shombith	1.0	24.0
C6	Audio coverage pass: menu bed, freestyle bed, per-minigame beds, UI stings. Fill the gaps that would read as silence in a trailer.	Charles	4.0	28.0
C7	Instrumentation and analytics buildout: event coverage against the locked schema, dashboard construction, end-to-end validation of the pipeline. Now includes wave cohorting , so every funnel and retention chart splits by invite wave — the paid-EA gate reads directly off these dashboards.	Shombith, Ian	5.0	33.0
C8	Daily thirty-minute all-modes play session with logged findings, running for the duration of the program	Andrew	3.0	36.0
C9	Quest and progression dialogue. Author the dialogue that carries the quest chain and load it into the existing dialogue runtime. The system is built; this is the content that runs through it.	Caleb, Garrett, Shombith	6.0	42.0
C10	Quest and progression data update in UGS. Update the quest and progression data in Cloud Save so unlock state, quest claims, and progression persist and roam correctly. A data and configuration pass on a shipped system. One calendar week.	Shombith	5.0	47.0
C11	Test and finalise the quest and progression system end to end: a fresh account through the full chain, claim and unlock behaviour, and cloud persistence across devices. Andrew leads testing; the rest of the group finalises against what it finds.	Andrew, Shombith, Caleb, Garrett	4.0	51.0
Workstream C subtotal			36.0	51.0

Remaining work, part three

Workstreams D and E · 48.5 person-days

D · Stability gate and load time 2 to 3 weeks · Garrett leading, with Shombith, Yash and Andrew

Quality bar carried forward unchanged: zero P0 or P1 defects at gate, and no more than ten P2 defects with documented workarounds. The gate now stands between Wave 0 and Wave 1 rather than before a paid launch.

#	TASK	OWNER	DAYS	RUNNING
D1	Profiling session on the floor machine: four-player Tournament at intensity four. Lock the hardware floor and the frame and memory targets.	Yash	3.0	54.0
D2	Load time, every game mode at every intensity. Measure cold boot to menu and menu to first playable frame across the full mode and intensity matrix, then reduce it. Bootstrap sequence, scene load, and asset warm-up are the candidates. One calendar week, with a published load-time target set alongside the frame and memory targets.	Shombith, Yash, Andrew	8.0	62.0
D3	Two-hour soak across freestyle and back-to-back tournaments: memory growth, GC spikes, prism-count ceiling behaviour	Yash	2.0	64.0
D4	Multiplayer regression: the existing party and presence suites, plus four-player thirty-minute disconnect and rejoin scenarios	Andrew	4.0	68.0
D5	Bug bash in week five, seeded with Wave 0 findings and triaged to the P0 through P3 rubric	Yash, Andrew, Garrett	5.0	73.0
D6	Signed exit checklist before Wave 1 opens to outsiders	Garrett	1.0	74.0
Workstream D subtotal			23.0	74.0

E · Marketing minimum and wave operations Runs weeks 1 to 6 · Caleb and Will, with Shombith or Yash for in-game integration

#	TASK	OWNER	DAYS	RUNNING
E1	Positioning one-pager: "Party Game for Pilots", three pillars, now framed for an invite era — scarcity is the story, and the paid-EA beat is the held-back headline	Caleb	1.0	75.0
E2	Steam copy pack: short and long description, feature bullets honest that this is an invite-only early development build, how to request access, tags, and the Q and A text from A4	Caleb	3.0	78.0
E3	Capsule and key art set across all five required sizes. Largest single art item and a gate on A5.	Will	6.0	84.0
E4	Five or more screenshots at 1920 by 1080: one per minigame plus Tournament and freestyle	Will	1.0	85.0
E5	Trailer version one, sixty seconds or less, plus a thirty-second social cut, captured from the real build and gameplay-first. Retained in this window by decision: the page sells the signup queue now and is trailer-ready for the paid-EA beat.	Will	6.0	91.0
E6	Discord live and linked from the Steam page, plus a basic landing page. Discord is the invite-phase community hub: feedback channels per wave, and the place testers learn their friend invites exist.	Caleb	1.0	92.0
E7	Wave 0: friends and family, ten to twenty-five people, granted through the real Playtest app. Validates the grant flow, upload pipeline, overlay, and first-session flow in a single beat, and produces quotes and clips for the page. Absorbs the prior plan's closed playtest.	Caleb, Shombith / Yash	4.0	96.0
E8	Invite-day communications drafted and scheduled: playtest announcement, Discord, social, and a press note that keys are not for sale	Caleb	1.0	97.0
E9	Funnel baseline and weekly tracking from the day the page goes live: wishlists, signup queue depth, grant-to-play conversion, invite redemption	Caleb	0.5	97.5
E10	Wave operations, weeks five and six. Execute the signed wave policy: grant batches from the queue, switch on friend invites after Wave 1 stabilises, tune invite allocation, watch concurrency against UGS Relay capacity, pause levers tested once on purpose.	Caleb	2.0	99.5
Workstream E subtotal			25.5	99.5

F · Legal and compliance 1 week · Shombith and Caleb

#	TASK	OWNER	DAYS	RUNNING
F1	Host the privacy policy at a public URL and link it in-game and on the store page. Template already written; the in-game settings row already exists.	Shombith	1.0	100.5
F2	Support contact, email or Discord, live on the store page	Caleb	0.5	101.0
F3	EULA decision. Steam's default Subscriber Agreement suffices unless custom terms are needed; confirm it also covers the Playtest cohort, and note Valve prohibits charging for Playtest access in any form.	Caleb	0.5	101.5
F4	Confirm the analytics and crash consent flow satisfies GDPR and COPPA posture for a PC-only invite program. Consent gating is already implemented; extended to note the Playtest cohort explicitly. A review rather than a build.	Shombith	1.0	102.5
Workstream F subtotal			3.0	102.5

Risk register

LEVEL	RISK AND MITIGATION
HIGH	Art capacity. Capsules and the trailer are 13 days on one contributor inside a two-week window — unchanged, since the trailer stays in this window by decision. Mitigation: both start in week one, and the trailer cut can be split to a second resource if week three slips. The pressure release that no longer exists on the paid path still exists here: a late trailer delays page polish, not the milestone.
HIGH	Steamworks processing. Identity, tax, and banking verification is outside our control, and the one-week estimate assumes a clean first pass. Mitigation: A1 starts day one, ahead of every dependent item, so a slow approval never blocks work that could have proceeded.
MEDIUM	Review bounce. Two Valve reviews now sit mid-plan: the store page and the Playtest build, each one to five business days with possible rejection on technicalities. Mitigation: both submit at the end of week three, four full weeks before the milestone — a structurally better position than the prior plan's single week-six submission — and week six retains buffer for one late bounce.
MEDIUM	Invite compounding versus capacity. New risk. Friend invites grow the cohort geometrically, and concurrency drives UGS Relay cost and support load. Mitigation: the signed wave policy in A6 caps weekly grants, invites switch on only after Wave 1 stabilises, telemetry gates each enlargement, and Steamworks can pause grants and invites per wave immediately.

Six-week critical path Relative weeks, anchored to kickoff

Four workstreams still start in week one so the two external-lead-time items, the Steamworks account and the capsule art, are never the reason a later item waits. The structural change: Steam review moves from a week-six cliff to a week-three checkpoint, and the back of the plan becomes wave execution.

WORKSTREAM	WEEK 1	WEEK 2	WEEK 3	WEEK 4	WEEK 5	WEEK 6
A · Steam and Playtest Shombith, Caleb, Garrett						
B · Build and pipeline Shombith						
C · In-game, quests, analytics Shombith, Ian, Caleb, Garrett, Charles, Andrew						
D · Stability and load time Garrett, Shombith, Yash, Andrew						
E · Marketing and waves Caleb, Will						
F · Legal Shombith, Caleb						

Solid bars are primary execution. Lighter bars are trailing work that finishes alongside the next phase. Black bars are gates: the week-three submission of page and Playtest build for Steam review, the week-five exit sign-off before Wave 1, and the invite program going and staying live.

WEEK	MILESTONE
Week 1	Steamworks account, fee, and surveys submitted. Playtest child app created, named, and configured with Request Access and friend invites. Windows build profile committed and PC sanity pass begins. Privacy policy hosted and legal decisions closed. Capsule art and positioning copy start.
Week 2	Coming Soon page live with the Playtest signup section — wishlists and the signup queue both start compounding while grants hold at zero. SteamPipe pipeline lands targeting both appIDs, automated depot build, and crash reporting. In-game validation, quest dialogue authoring, and the analytics buildout begin.
Week 3	Build pipeline complete. Store page and Playtest build submitted for Steam review — the bounce buffer starts here, not in week six. De-scope sweep, economy tuning, audio pass, and the quest and progression data update in UGS in progress. Capsule art delivered to the store page. Performance floor confirmed on the 1060-class machine, and the load-time week runs across every mode and intensity.
Week 4	Wave 0: friends and family, ten to twenty-five people, through the real Playtest app — grant flow, overlay, and first-session flow validated together on the approved build. Multiplayer regression and soak testing run. Trailer and final screenshots onto the page.
Week 5	Bug bash seeded with Wave 0 findings, triaged to the P0 through P3 rubric. Quest and progression system tested end to end and finalised. Exit checklist signed. Wave 1: the first one hundred to two hundred and fifty outsiders granted from the signup queue , with invite-day communications out.
Week 6	Friend invites switch on and the invite program reaches steady state : weekly grant waves from the queue, one to three compounding invites per tester, telemetry cohorted by wave, zero review surface. Remainder of the week held as buffer for one review bounce or a capacity pause. This is the Deadlock milestone.

Definition of done

All eight simultaneously true.

1. Steam page live with the Playtest signup section, passed review, with wishlist and signup-queue tracking running.
2. Playtest build approved and active; Wave 0 and Wave 1 granted; friend invites enabled at one to three per tester.
3. A fresh install on the floor machine reaches a completed four-player Tournament, humans and bots, with zero P0 or P1 defects.
4. A fresh account completes the quest chain, with unlocks and progression persisting through Cloud Save.
5. Cold boot to playable meets the load-time target in every game mode at every intensity.
6. Crash reporting and funnel telemetry visible in dashboards from Playtest builds, cohorted by wave.
7. Zero public review surface: the base app is unreleased and the Playtest is unreviewable by design.
8. The paid-EA gate criteria are published and Garrett has signed the exit checklist.

The paid-EA gate, not a date

Provisional bars, to be ratified at the next checkpoint. When all hold for two consecutive weeks, the deferred items — pricing, discount, EA questionnaire, purchasable release — execute as a two-week conversion sprint. The Path of Exile transition is the beat after that.

- **Retention.** D1 at or above 35 percent and D7 at or above 15 percent across two consecutive waves.
- **Stability.** Crash-free sessions at or above 99.5 percent; zero P0 or P1 and no more than ten documented P2 on a rolling two-week window.
- **Onboarding.** Median time-to-Tournament at or under ten minutes for unaided new players.
- **Demand.** Signup queue and wishlist velocity still growing at gate time, so the paid launch opens into pull rather than push.

Summary

Cosmic Shore remains feature-complete with zero features left to build. The six-week path now ends at a Deadlock-style invite program — a free Steam Playtest with a Request Access queue and compounding friend invites — instead of a paid Early Access launch. The review score cannot form during this phase: Playtest participants cannot post reviews and the base app stays unreleased. Residual work is 102.5 person-days across the same eight people, a net increase of 2.0 over the prior plan, with the Steam review risk moved from a week-six cliff to a week-three checkpoint. The Path of Exile-style paid transition is preserved intact as the next milestone, triggered by published cohort metrics rather than a calendar date.